



WINNER OF 28 PULITZER PRIZES FOR EXCELLENCE IN JOURNALISM

Chicago Tribune



QUESTIONS? CALL 1-800-TRIBUNE

SATURDAY, DECEMBER 28, 2024

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Larry Farmer's road less traveled, from player at powerhouse UCLA under John Wooden to girls coach at tiny Woodlands Academy in Lake Forest



PASSING ON A PYRAMID OF SUCCESS



Above: UCLA star Bill Walton gets nudged into teammate Larry Farmer, left, by Drake University's Dennis Bell during play in the Sugar Bowl tournament in New Orleans on Dec. 30, 1972. **AP Top:** Farmer, now the girls basketball coach at Woodlands Academy of the Sacred Heart in Lake Forest, huddles with his team during a game against Rochelle Zell Jewish High School on Dec. 16. Farmer is in his third season as coach at the all-girls school. **ARMANDO L. SANCHEZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

By Neil Milbert
Chicago Tribune

Far from Pauley Pavilion in sun-kissed Los Angeles, where Larry Farmer played for the greatest dynasty in college basketball history, he is preaching the gospel of his iconic coach, John Wooden, to high school girls in a small gym in frostbitten Lake Forest.

Farmer, 73, is in his third season as coach at Woodlands Academy of the Sacred Heart, an all-girls school renowned for its academic environment. Woodlands, with an enrollment of 249 students, has been ranked the No. 1 all-girls high school in Illinois for eight straight years by the independent academic research organization Niche.

"One of the huge differences between this year and my first year is then we barely had enough to make a team and often I had to make two practice plans," Farmer said. "One was if we had 10 girls so we could scrimmage. The other was to do full-court drills four-against-four."

"Now we have 21 girls on varsity and junior varsity — the

Turn to Coach, Page 5

Many split on CEO's death

Poll respondents believe insurance industry shares responsibility for shooting

By Linley Sanders, Tom Murphy and Amelia Thomson-Deveaux
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — Most Americans believe health insurance profits and coverage denials share responsibility for the killing of UnitedHealthcare's CEO — although not as much as the person who pulled the trigger, according to a new poll.

In the survey from NORC at the University of Chicago, 8 in 10 U.S. adults said the person who committed the killing has "a great deal" or "a moderate amount" of responsibility for the shooting of Brian Thompson.

Despite that, some have cast Luigi Mangione, the 26-year-old suspect charged with Thompson's homicide, as a heroic figure in the aftermath of his arrest, which gave rise to an outpouring of grievances about insurance companies. Police say the words "delay," "deny" and "depose" were scrawled on the ammunition investigators found at the scene, echoing a phrase commonly used to describe insurer tactics to avoid paying claims.

The Manhattan district attorney charged Mangione last week with multiple counts of murder, including as an act of terrorism; Mangione has pleaded not guilty.

Federal prosecutors have also brought charges over the shooting that carry the possibility of the death penalty, while the maximum sentence for the state charges is life in prison without parole.

Authorities say Mangione gunned down Thompson as he was walking to an investor conference in midtown Manhattan in New York City on the morning of Dec. 4.

UnitedHealthcare has said Mangione was not a client.

Seven in 10 adults say denials for health care coverage by insurance companies, or the profits made by health insurance companies, also bear at least "a moderate amount" of responsibility for Thompson's death. Younger Americans are particularly likely to see the killing as the result of a confluence of forces rather than just one person's action.

The poll finds that the story of the slaying is being followed widely; 7 in

Turn to CEO, Page 4

Exhibit honors sculptor who made metal feel 'like emotion'

Lincoln library gallery sparks imagery of freedom, growth

By Jeremy Gorner
Chicago Tribune

SPRINGFIELD — Chicago sculptor Richard Hunt's inspiration as an artist was sparked in part by the murder of Emmett Till, the 14-year-old South Side boy who was tortured and lynched during a visit to Mississippi.

Hunt grew up not far from where Till lived and attended Till's open-casket funeral, which became a catalyst for the social-justice-centered themes that dominated Hunt's career of some 70 years.

"It was obviously something to respond to," Hunt, who died a year ago at 88, is quoted as saying on his website.

Through April, work by Hunt is on display at Springfield's Abraham Lincoln Presidential Library and Museum in an exhibit entitled "Freedom in Form: Richard Hunt."

Hunt's sculptures are prominently displayed in museum collections and public

spaces around the country. Despite such national recognition, Eric W. Stephenson, the director of Hunt's Chicago studio in Lincoln Park, said Hunt preferred to work out of Chicago instead of "the perceived art meccas" of New York City and Los Angeles.

"Dealing with industrial materials, Chicago is kind of a haven for public art and resources and, to be fair, accessibility and expense. It's a little bit cheaper," said Stephenson, who is also a sculptor. "It was also a way for him to just truly focus on the work and kind of eliminate some of those outside distractions that happened when you're closer to the center of the art world."

The Springfield museum's interest in staging an exhibit of his work goes back a few years. After JB Pritzker became governor in 2019, he and his wife, MK, commissioned one of Hunt's sculptures, a bronze piece called "Growing Flowing," for the Governor's Mansion in Springfield. Later, April 24, 2023, was declared Richard Hunt Day in Illinois.

According to Jon Ott, Hunt's official

Turn to Sculptor, Page 3



The late sculptor Richard Hunt in his studio in 2023. Hunt's work is featured through April in an exhibit at the Abraham Lincoln Presidential Library. **E. JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

